City of Cambridge

RES 2026-136
FIRST IN COUNCIL
September 28, 2026

MAYOR SIDDIQUI

WHEREAS: The City Council was deeply saddened to learn of the passing of longtime Cambridge resident Dr. Felton “Tony” James Earls III on September 5, 2026, at the age of 84; and

WHEREAS: Born in New Orleans in 1942 and raised in Memphis, Dr. Earls graduated from Booker T. Washington High School and Howard University, where he earned a Bachelor of Science degree in Chemistry in 1963 and a Doctor of Medicine degree in 1967; and

WHEREAS: Dr. Earls devoted his career to understanding the lives of children, families, and communities, bringing together child psychiatry, epidemiology, public health, and social science to illuminate how the environments in which young people grow up shape their health and well-being; and

WHEREAS: Dr. Earls joined the faculty of Harvard Medical School in 1974, and later served at Washington University School of Medicine in St. Louis as Professor of Child Psychiatry and Director of the Division of Child Psychiatry, before returning to Harvard in 1989; and

WHEREAS: Dr. Earls’s groundbreaking work included leading a major, multi-year study of urban neighborhoods that advanced the concept of collective efficacy and helped define how trust, shared responsibility, and civic engagement contribute to safer, stronger communities; and

WHEREAS: Dr. Earls’s commitment to civic engagement extended deeply into his own community, where he served as an early member of Cambridge Youth Council, advocating for the creation of meaningful opportunities for youth participation in civic life; and

WHEREAS: Alongside his wife and collaborator, Mary “Maya” Carlson, he conducted international research on children’s rights and civic agency, emphasizing the importance of recognizing young people as contributors whose perspectives enrich their communities; and

WHEREAS: He further advanced human rights and global public health through his leadership of the Harvard South Africa Fellowship Program and service on the Board of Directors of Physicians for Human Rights; and

WHEREAS: Dr. Earls is survived by his wife, his two daughters, and six grandchildren, and will be profoundly missed by his family, friends, colleagues, and all those who benefited

from his intellect, compassion, and commitment to community; now therefore be it

RESOLVED: That the City Council go on record honoring the life and legacy of Dr. Felton “Tony” James Earls III and extending its deepest sympathy to his family; and be it further

RESOLVED: That the City Clerk be and hereby is requested to forward a suitably engrossed copy of this resolution to the family of Dr. Tony James Earls III on behalf of the entire City Council.

A true copy;

ATTEST:-

Paula M. Crane,
Interim City Clerk

City of Cambridge

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